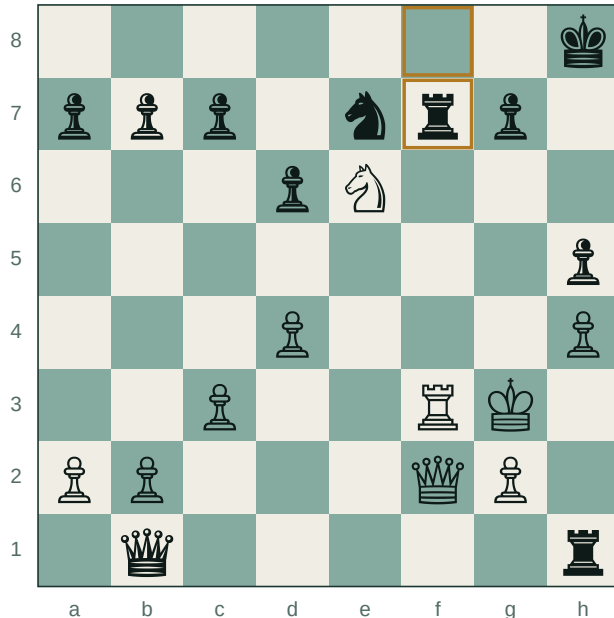


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 27

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 26...Rxf7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

27. Rxf7 Qd3+ 28. Qf3

27.Rxf7 The rook captures the rook on f7. Recorded reply: **27...Qd3+**.

28.Qf3 The queen moves from f2 to f3.

At the end, nominal material is White 23 / Black 23 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +5. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +5: the balance goes from -5 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on h8. Geometrically undefended: rook on f7. Check for tactical protection.